

THIS SEASON

To read, to hear, to make

To read. *In Praise of Shadows* by Jun'ichirō Tanizaki — a short 1933 essay on the beauty of dimness, lacquer and quiet, and the single best thing ever written on why a softly-lit room feels alive. Read it in an afternoon; think about it for years.

To learn. The names of your own local season. Keep a note of what the garden does each five-day week — first bud, first bee, first open blossom. You are keeping your own almanac, the way Japan has for centuries.

To make. One ikebana arrangement a week, from page 22 — three stems, three heights, a great deal of air. A discipline that costs nothing and rewards attention.

To notice. The lengthening of the light. Mark where the evening sun lands on the wall this week, and again in a month. Designing a calm home begins with watching how the light already moves through it.

"A calm home is less a set of purchases than a way of paying attention."